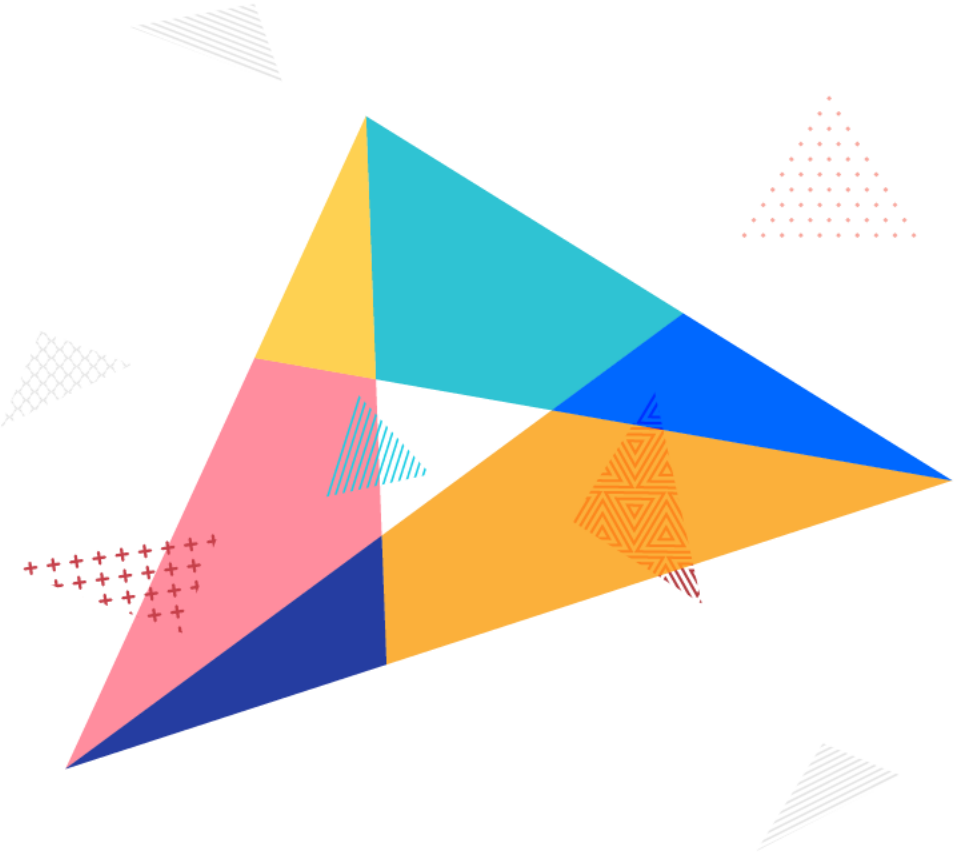
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Topic 2: Driving Operational Execution

Dr Phuong (Emmy) Hoang

Learning Outcomes

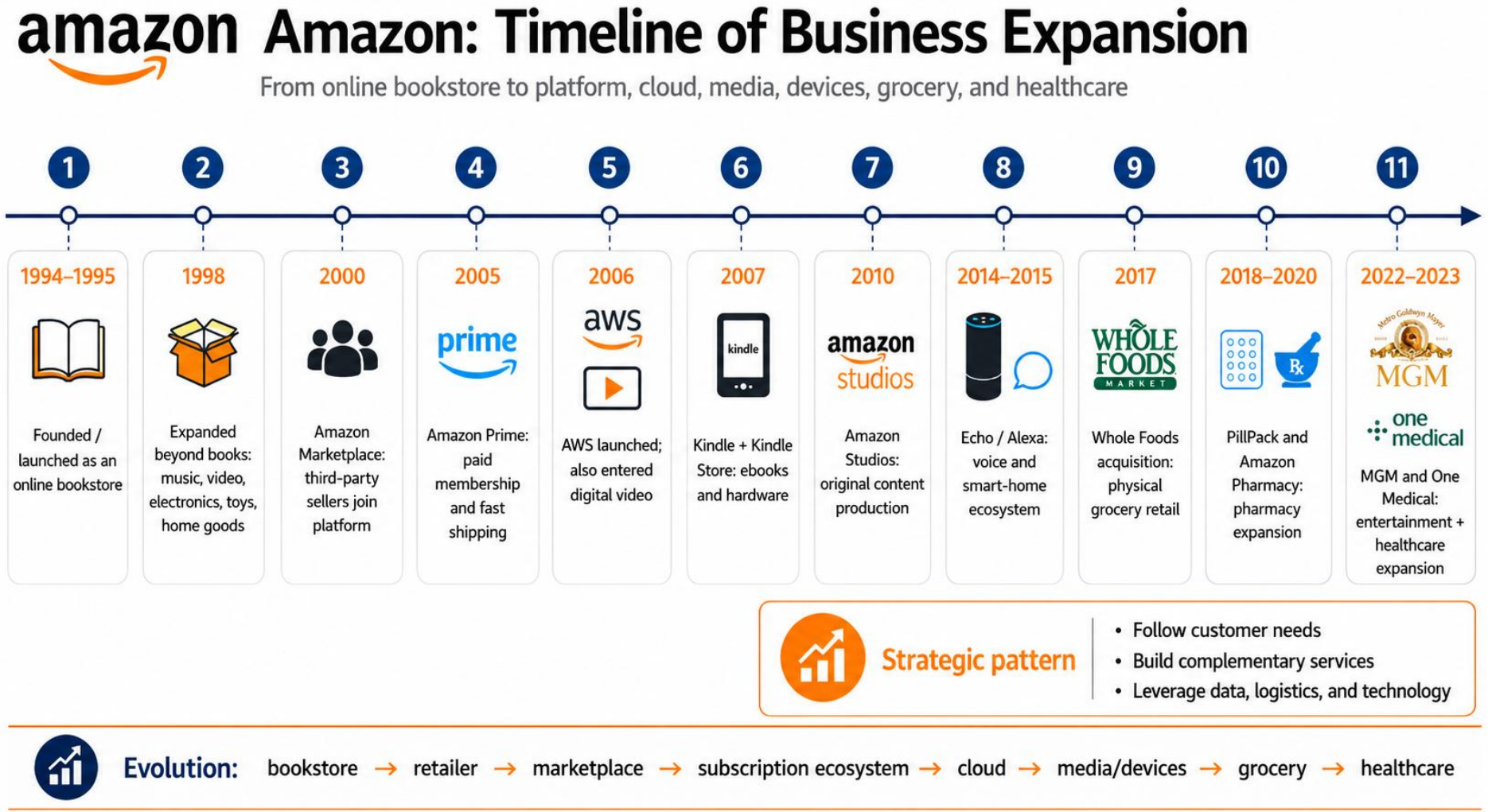
- Formulate clear outcomes, KPIs and measurement criteria for assigned team work.
- Design a progress-monitoring and quality-assurance rhythm appropriate to their team's delivery context.
- Diagnose execution bottlenecks and prioritise resolution actions based on impact.
- Adjust execution plans in response to performance data and feedback.

Today’s learning path

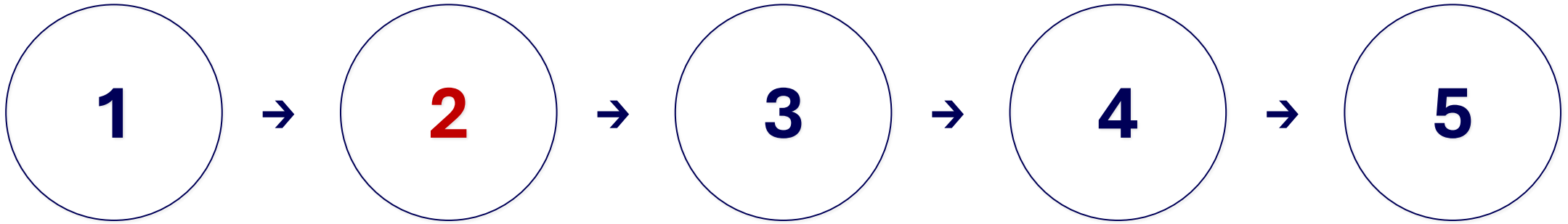


1. Setting the Context
2. From Strategy to Managerial Execution
3. From Direction to Measurable Results
4. From Measures to Management Signals
5. Build and Run the Execution System

Amazon's journey: From One Business to an Ecosystem



Next


1
2
3
4
5
Setting the Context
From Strategy to Managerial Execution
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From Insight to Impact: The Strategic Management Cycle

Business decisions rarely move in a straight line. Evidence, execution data and learning continually reshape the next decision cycle.



Management implication Good execution begins before execution: clarify the problem, define success, translate priorities into KPIs, then adjust when evidence changes.

↺ **Feedback loop** Evaluation produces new evidence, allowing leaders to revise assumptions, priorities and execution choices.

From Organisational Direction to Team Delivery

Each level translates broader organisational direction into increasingly specific choices and team action

Direction cascades down

1. Corporate Strategy
Where will the organisation compete?
Portfolio • markets • ecosystems • resource allocation

2. Business Strategy
How will the business compete and succeed?
Target customers • value proposition • positioning • growth

3. Functional Strategy
How will each function support the business strategy?
Product • tech • marketing • people • operations

4. Operational Execution
What must teams deliver, by when and how?
OKRs • KPIs • owners • milestones • risk controls

Manager translation lens

Translate priorities into:

- **team outcomes**
- **success measures**
- **resource choices**
- **adaptive execution**

This is the bridge between Think Strategically and Drive Impact.

From Zalo Direction to Team Execution

Level	Illustrative Zalo question
Corporate	Which businesses and platforms should form the Zalo ecosystem, and how should resources be allocated across messaging, media, advertising, life utilities and AI?
Business	How should Zalo Messaging, Zing MP3, Adtima, Báo Mới or Zalo AI create distinctive value and succeed in their respective markets?
Functional	What must Product, Technology, Marketing, People and Operations contribute to support each platform's strategy?
Operational	What outcomes, OKRs, releases, projects, responsibilities, timelines and KPIs must each team deliver this quarter?

Operational Execution Turns Direction into Results



Definition

Operational execution is the process of translating goals into coordinated actions, monitoring whether actions create intended results, and correcting the plan when evidence shows delivery is moving off track.

Execution is not just effort. It is a system for turning effort into results.

Execution Fails When Activity Replaces Results

Individual contributor	Manager
Delivers own work	Creates the team delivery system
Solves assigned problems	Clarifies outcomes and priorities
Reports progress	Creates visibility and decision rhythm
Escalates blockers	Removes constraints and adjusts execution

Leadership transition in practice: your value comes from how the system performs, not only from what you personally solve.



Take a 15-Minute Break

After the break: From Direction to Measurable Results

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Next

1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5

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Three Manager Moves That Drive Execution

We need a shared vocabulary for turning direction into team results.

First-line manager shift
from completing assigned work to connecting direction, people and results

1
Translate
turn broad direction into team outcomes

→

2
Coordinate
align people, work and resources

→

3
Adjust
use evidence to correct and improve execution

Six term families used in operational execution

Direction	Measurement	Planning	Ownership	Coordination	Adaptation
Goal • objective outcome • impact	Metric • KPI target • baseline	OKR • initiative milestone • dependency	Owner • RACI resources • capacity	Cadence • status blocker • escalation	Risk • issue mitigation • learning

Core idea **A goal provides direction. A KPI measures progress. A target defines the required level. An initiative creates change. An owner drives delivery. Execution turns these into results.**

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Direction: What result are we trying to create?

The first execution mistake is confusing activity with impact.

From broad direction to value

Goal: broad destination
What are we trying to achieve?

↓

Objective: specific result
What specifically must be achieved?

↓

Output: thing produced
What will we produce?

↓

Outcome: change created
What change or value should result?

↓

Impact: broader value
Why does this result matter?

Three terms learners often confuse

Output
Launch a new onboarding feature

→

Outcome
New users complete onboarding faster

→

Impact
Higher activation and retention

Execution boundaries

Success criteria
What does "done well" look like?

Scope
What is included and excluded?

Requirement
What must the solution provide?

Constraint
What limits our options?

Assumption
What are we taking for granted?

Manager check: **Before assigning work, clarify the expected change, the deliverable, the boundaries and the assumptions.**

From goal to execution-ready objective

Concept	Meaning	Example
Goal	Broad direction	Improve onboarding
Objective	Specific result	Reduce onboarding completion time by 20% by Q4
Task	Work to be done	Redesign tutorial screens

If the objective is vague, measurement and coordination become vague too.

SMART Creates Minimum Execution Clarity

S

Specific

Who, what and how are clear

M

Measurable

Progress or success can be assessed

A

Achievable

Realistic with available resources

R

Relevant

Connected to business or team goals

T

Time-bound

Has a defined timeframe

Use SMART to create minimum clarity before discussing KPIs, monitoring or course correction.

Turning a vague goal into a SMART objective

Weak

Improve team responsiveness.

→

SMART

Reduce average internal response time for priority support requests from 24 hours to 12 hours by 30 September.

What changed?

The objective now has a defined measure, baseline, target and timeframe.

SMART can still measure the wrong result

Example objective

Launch Smart Assist by Friday.

This is specific, measurable and time-bound.

- What user outcome should improve?
- What quality boundary matters?
- What risk should be protected?
- What adoption signal matters?
- What threshold triggers a change?

SMART helps with clarity. It does not guarantee the team is measuring the right result.

Add the outcome, evidence and guardrails

When the path is substantially known

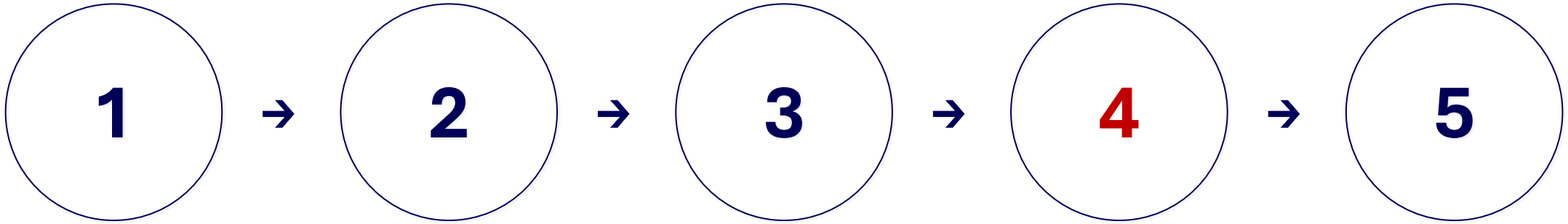
By [date], [beneficiary] will experience [observable change] from [baseline] to [target], while [quality/risk boundary] remains protected.

When the work is uncertain

By [date], we will test [critical assumption] using [specified evidence], enabling a decision about [next action].

Known path → performance objective. Uncertain path → learning or validation objective.

Next



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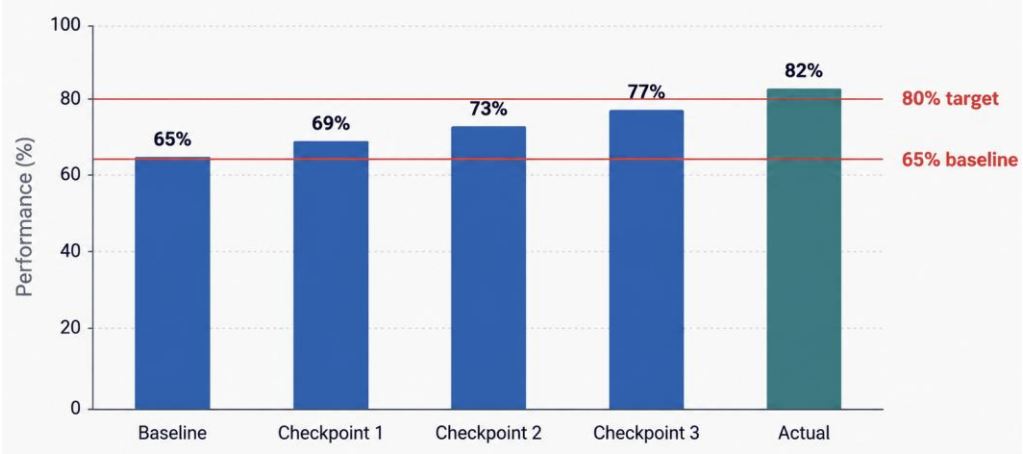
Measurement: How will we know we are on track?

Metrics create visibility; KPIs show whether the most important results are moving.

Metric, KPI, baseline and target

Metric Any measure we can track Number of users completing onboarding	**KPI** The key measure of success Onboarding completion rate
Baseline Where we start Current completion rate: 65%	**Target** The required level Increase to 80% by Q4

Performance target



Leading vs lagging indicators

Leading indicator Early signal that the result may happen Example: % users reaching step 2	**Lagging indicator** Final result after work has happened Example: completion rate at quarter end

Performance control terms

Quality standard How good must the output be?	**Variance** How far are we from plan?
Benchmark What standard do we compare with?	**Dashboard** What is the current performance picture?

Manager check **Ask which KPI truly shows success, what is the starting point, and what target must be reached by when?**

Common mistake: Treating every metric as a KPI

A useful KPI should answer:

What decision could this measure change?

Weak KPI candidates

- number of meetings held
- number of tasks opened
- number of reports sent

Stronger KPI candidates

- decision cycle time
- issue resolution rate
- adoption with quality guardrail

Baseline and target make progress visible

Example KPI structure

KPI: weekly active use
Baseline: 18%
Target: 35%
Deadline: 30 September
Guardrail: correction rate below 5%

Without a baseline, the team cannot see how far it has moved. Without a target, the team cannot see what “enough” means.

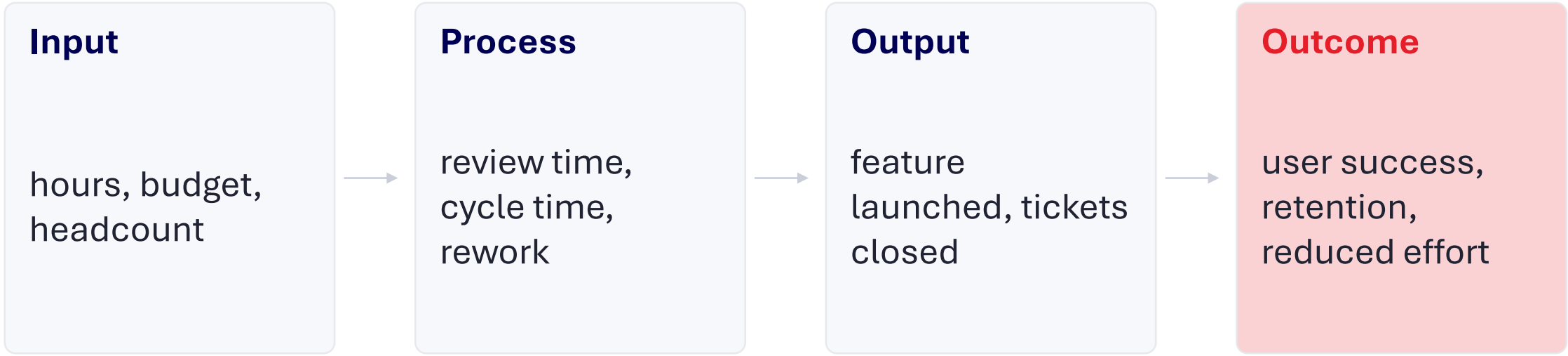
Leading indicators help managers act early

Type	Question	Example
Leading	Are we moving in the right direction?	Trial activation, repeat use, unresolved dependency
Lagging	Did we achieve the outcome?	Adoption, revenue, retention, satisfaction

Earlier signal → **Later result**

Managers need both: early movement and final value.

Know what you are measuring: Input to outcome



Execution quality improves when teams stop confusing outputs with outcomes.

Build a balanced execution signal stack

Outcome	Did value occur?
Driver	Are we moving?
Guardrail	What must stay healthy?
Flow	Where is work waiting or accumulating?

A single KPI rarely gives enough visibility for execution decisions.

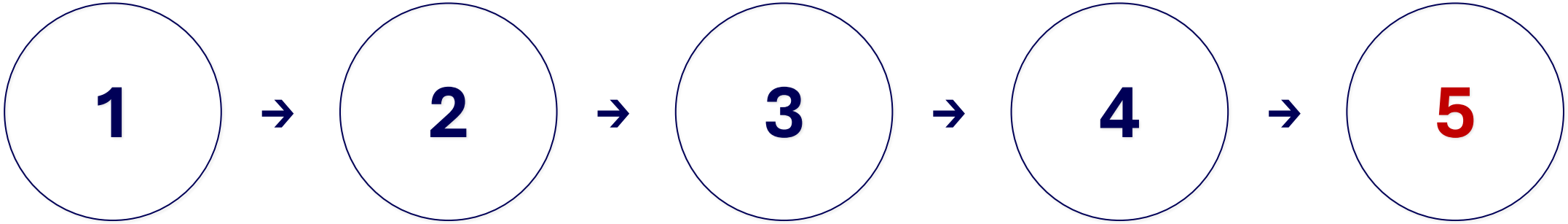
Stress-test the KPI before you use it

Before adopting a KPI, try to break it.

1. Can this number improve while the outcome worsens?
2. Can the team game it?
3. What quality or risk guardrail is needed?
4. What decision will this measure change?

Provocation: the most dangerous KPI is one the team can improve while the outcome worsens.

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Planning: How will the goal become coordinated work?

Translation and planning turn objectives into choices, initiatives, milestones and dependencies.

OKR logic

Objective
What do we want to achieve?

+

Key Results
How will we know?

Priorities and trade-offs

Priority
What should receive attention first?

Trade-off
What are we willing to give up?

Roadmap | **Work plan** | **Timeline** | **Deadline**

Milestone | **Dependency** | **Critical path**

Work breakdown

Initiative
major effort to achieve objective

Project
temporary effort with deliverables

Workstream
related activities within a larger effort

Action / Task
specific unit of work

Roadmap to delivery



Manager check **A good plan shows what will be done, what comes first, what depends on what, and where trade-offs are being made.**

Zalo Drive Impact: clarify outcomes, prioritise work, monitor progress, remove bottlenecks and adjust based on evidence.

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Create the Team Delivery System

Operational execution is a management system, not a task list.

Ownership essentials

Owner
Who owns this?

Responsibility
Who must do the work?

Accountability
Who answers for the outcome?

RACI
Responsible, Accountable, Consulted, Informed

Resource / Capacity
What do we need, and how much can we handle?

Rule of thumb
Many people can be responsible; one person should be accountable.

Operational execution loop

OWN
Owner
Accountability
Decision rights

→

COORDINATE
Cadence
Status
Blockers

↓

Deliver results, then learn and adjust

↓

CONTROL
Risk
Issue
Mitigation

←

ADAPT
Corrective action
Course correction
Lessons learned

Coordination + adaptation terms

Cadence How often do we review?

Status Where does work stand?

Blocker What stops progress now?

Bottleneck Where is the system slowing?

Escalation When should this be raised?

Risk What might happen?

Issue What has already gone wrong?

Mitigation How can risk be reduced?

Course correction What must change now?

Feedback loop How does learning improve action?

Example thread **Objective: Reduce onboarding friction → KPI: completion rate → Target: 80% → Initiative: redesign journey → Owner: PM → Risk: engineering capacity → Adjustment: reduce scope or add resources.**

Manager check **Execution fails when ownership is unclear, coordination is weak, risks are unmanaged, or learning is ignored.**

Zalo Drive Impact: clarify outcomes, prioritise work, monitor progress, remove bottlenecks and adjust based on evidence.

Design a Review Rhythm with Purpose and Authority

Review type	Purpose	Example cadence
Daily check	Unblock urgent issues	10 - 15 minutes
Weekly review	Trend, quality, dependency	30– - 45 minutes
Milestone gate	Continue, adjust, pause	Before launch or handoff

The cadence should match the speed and risk of the work.

Define Response Thresholds Before Problems Escalate

Signal class	Meaning	Response
Act now	Serious threshold crossed	Pause, contain, escalate
Act this cycle	Trend weakening	Diagnose and adjust
Observe and learn	Within tolerance	Continue monitoring

The best time to decide how to respond to a warning is before the warning appears.

Monitor the Work System, Not the Person

Good visibility

- helps the team see work state
- reveals dependencies
- surfaces risk early
- supports decisions

Poor visibility

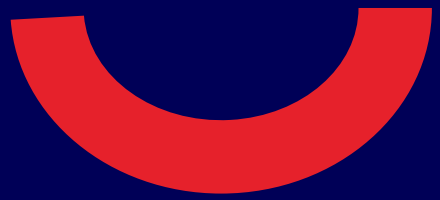
- watches people
- creates fear
- encourages hiding
- increases reporting burden

Bad news travels at the speed permitted by the team climate.

Case in point

IMPROVING NEW-ACCOUNT ACTIVATION

Thank you!



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